

Zhaoyang Li

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 LinkedIn

 Github

 Homepage

Education

PhD Rutgers University–New Brunswick	Sep 2026 - Present
• Computer Science; Robot Learning Lab	
MS University of California San Diego	Sep 2023 - Jun 2025
• Electrical and Computer Engineering (Intelligent Systems, Robotics & Control)	
BS University of Wisconsin–Madison,	Jan 2021 - May 2023
• Double Major in Computer Science & Mathematics	

Research Interests

My research focuses on developing embodied agents that perceive, reason, and act in the physical world. I work at the intersection of **multimodal learning**, **robot learning**, and **world models** with a focus on **(1).** improving the robustness of vision–language models and their deployment in robotics, **(2).** developing efficient control and planning policies, and **(3).** learning structured, object-centric world models that support prediction and planning. Ultimately, I aim to build reliable, interpretable agents that generalize to real-world environments.

Publications & Preprints

* indicates equal contributions.

1. **Zhaoyang Li***, Zhan Ling*, Yuchen Zhou, Litian Gong, Erdem Biyik, Hao Su. “ORIC: Benchmarking Object Recognition under Contextual Incongruity in Large Vision-Language Models.”, in Proceedings of the IEEE / CVF Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition Conference (**CVPR**), 2026 [\[Paper\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)
2. **Zhaoyang Li**, Sushaanth Srinivasan, Ninad Ekbote, Pengtao Xie. “A Multi-modal Large Language Model for Predicting Mechanisms of Drug Interactions.” Submitted to **Nature Biomedical Engineering**.
3. Tongzhou Mu*, **Zhaoyang Li***, Stanisław Wiktor Strzelecki*, Xiu Yuan, Yunchao Yao, Litian Liang, Aditya Gulati, Hao Su. “When Should We Prefer State-to-Visual DAgger Over Visual Reinforcement Learning?”, in Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence (**AAAI**), 2025 [\[Paper\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)
4. Yifei Zhang, Yusen Jiao, Jiayi Chen, **Zhaoyang Li**, Huaxiu Yao, Jieyu Zhang, Frederic Sala. “Just Select Twice: Leveraging Low-Quality Data to Improve Data Selection.”, ATTRIB Workshop at **NeurIPS** 2024; extended version in submission. [\[Paper\]](#)

Research Experience & Project

Bayesian Flow Networks for Robotic Manipulation (Project Lead)

Advisor: Prof. Erdem Biyik, USC

Dec 2025 – Apr 2026
Los Angeles, CA

- Developed BFN Policy, a Bayesian Flow Network–based imitation learning method that natively models hybrid (discrete–continuous) action spaces, avoiding the relaxation-and-rounding that breaks diffusion policies.
- Outperformed diffusion baselines on 7 of 8 parameterized-action benchmarks (robust as discrete dimension grew) at $\sim 8\times$ faster inference; validated on real-robot Push-T (xArm, WidowX). First-author paper submitted to CoRL 2026.

Context-Incongruity Robustness for Large Vision Language Models (Project Lead)

Advisor: Prof. Hao Su (UC San Diego); Prof. Erdem Biyik (USC)

Aug 2024 - Sep 2025
San Diego, CA

- Built ORIC to generate context-incongruous object–context data via dual LLM- and CLIP-guided sampling, and released the ORIC-Bench benchmark; **published at CVPR 2026**.
- Benchmarked 18 LVLMs and 2 open-vocabulary detectors, exposing systematic recognition bias under contextual incongruity.
- Fine-tuned Qwen3-VL-8B-Instruct with Visual-RFT on 600 ORIC samples, boosting F1 and human-aligned predictions on ORIC-Bench, AMBER, and HallusionBench.

Multi-modal Language Model for Drug Interaction Prediction (Project Lead)

Advisor: Prof. Pengtao Xie; UC-San Diego

- Fine-tuned a multi-modal LLM with SMILES inputs to predict drug interaction status, degree, and mechanisms, integrating chemical informatics and NLP.
- Achieved strong performance: METEOR 0.42, BLEU-1 0.25, semantic similarity 0.57; outperforming GPT-4o (METEOR 0.16, BLEU-1 0.11, semantic similarity 0.30).

Dec 2024 - May 2025
San Diego, CA

Empirical Analysis of State-to-Visual (S2V) Imitation vs. Visual RL (Project Co-Lead)

Advisor: Prof. Hao Su, UC-San Diego

- Benchmarked State-to-Visual DAgger vs. visual RL across 16 tasks from ManiSkill, DM-Control, and Adroit; **published at AAAI 2025**.
- Showed S2V DAgger excels on hard tasks with more consistent performance and lower wall-clock time, with no universal winner across tasks.
- Built a standardized S2V pipeline and derived practical recommendations for visual policy learning.

Feb 2024 - Sep 2024
San Diego, CA

Simulation of the Connected and Automated Driving Systems

Advisor: Prof. Bin Ran; The Connected Automated Vehicle Highway System Group

- Simulated and optimized traffic systems in CARLA, enhancing traffic management models for improved efficiency.
- Refined object detection algorithms, including YOLO and Faster R-CNN, to improve vehicle detection and traffic control systems.

Sep 2021 - May 2022
Madison, WI

Industry Experiences

Computer Vision Algorithm Engineer | Mech-Mind Robotics Technologies Ltd.

- Developed algorithms for structured light 3D cameras, improving image accuracy and optimizing point cloud reconstruction for laser systems.
- Led the refinement of internal camera distortion models, significantly enhancing imaging fidelity and calibration precision.

Jun 2023 - Sep 2023
Beijing, China

Teaching

Teaching Assistant at UW-Madison

- CS540: Introduction to Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2023

Peer Mentor at UW-Madison

- CS537: Introduction to Operating System

Fall 2022

Professional Services

Reviewer

- AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence
- AAAI Workshop: Large Language Models and Generative AI for Health

Technical Skills

- **Languages:** English (Proficient; TOEFL 108, GRE 330 + 3.5), Chinese (Native)
- **Programming:** Python, C++, C, Java, Matlab, R, LaTeX, SQL
- **ML and Vision Frameworks:** PyTorch, TensorFlow, OpenCV, scikit-learn, SimpleITK, SPM12, TorchIO
- **Simulation and Robotics:** CARLA, MuJoCo, ManiSkill, DMControl, RoboMimic, WidowX, Adroit.
- **Developer Tools:** VS Code, Vim, IntelliJ IDEA, Visual Studio, Git, Docker, Kubernetes